Heart of Etheria

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/42194031.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
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Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Characters:
Horde Prime (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Bloodborne Fusion, Don't Have to Know Bloodborne (Video Game), Prime and his colonialist mind set are alive and well, PoV Horde Prime, Horde Prime Being a Jerk (She-Ra), Egotism on Display, Bloodborne Lore Heavy, Exposition, the welcome to the AU fic, no editing we die like meh, who's bloodborne lore is it? everyone's and no one's the way god intended, delicately sets the stage so I can crush my blorbos with a comically large angst hammer later, Racism, Minor Character Death, the heart of etheria, Blood Drinking, Blood and Injury

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Part 1 of We are born of the blood

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Heart of Etheria

by Nny11

Summary

Horde Prime seeks out an Ancient One, and sets off a chain of events that cannot be undone.

We are born of the blood, made men by the blood, undone by the blood. Our eyes are yet to open...fear the old blood.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Prime had been an unlikely fellow to find in an antiquated and backwater city like Etheria.

Etheria was ancient, crumbling, and unpleasant at best. Etherians had merely moved back into the city from their little mud hovels after the disappearance of the First Ones, not even bothering to build their own spaces. Almost like an infection they simply moved into the shell left by those who once ousted them and barely repaired what they could. Their obsession and intimacy with the dead showing through their own maligned actions. And that alone was enough for most in more civilized parts of the world to be wary, but it was not the main reason.

Prime smiled politely, pretending to sip at his tonic while he listened to the rabble ramble on. His refusal to drink had little to do with the taste and more to do with its particular contents. You see, most people were wary for a very good reason.

It was the blood, of course.

Long before he'd even known what he wanted to do with his life, Prime had heard the horror stories. Etherians would kidnap small children to drain their blood, and they'd drink it happily from skulls. They would kill anyone foolish enough to step foot in the city and use your body for their horrifying rituals. As a young boy

he’d imagined savages dancing and cackling around a fire, with hands and teeth strung around their necks.

It wasn’t *true* . But it was still a widely accepted “truth” outside the ancient walls.

Prime felt strongly that the people of Etheria were not monsters, merely misguided. They weren’t wrong about the properties of the blood they drank, in fact, most tinctures and tonics containing less than a few drops of the ancient blood *did* help cure mild ills. He’d been astounded when he’d first moved to the city, watching a frail woman swig directly from a bottle and her coughing stopped almost instantly. That was but one of countless exposures he’d now had. Yes, the blood did heal, not miraculously as some ancient texts and carvings suggested, but he’d watched small abrasions scab and heal over in seconds which was miraculous all the same.

For all his revulsion growing up, his fascination with the Etherian fascination with blood and death drew him in. More effective than any trap was how the tales weaponized his own curiosity.

Prime had still a very young man, nearly a child still, desperate to leave his mark on the world when he’d purchased his mansion. An academic absorbing information like a sponge from a people he believed he could help in a way that only he could. Prime had planned to study, learn, and then teach the Etherians the error of their ways. He’d never anticipated becoming so intertwined with the miracles performed by bottles.

The first time Prime had consumed blood had been when a careless worker swung around too quickly with some wood planks. He doesn't even remember getting hit, just being bored as he listened to someone blabbering on about some petty opinion they'd read in the paper that morning, and the next thing he can recall is being on the filthy cobblestone with his head aching and ears ringing. Someone pressed a glass neck to his lips, and turned around as he was, Prime drank. The ringing slipped higher and higher and stopped within seconds, his throbbing head slowed to a dull ache, and his wits returned.

It had been…eye opening.

As one might assume from all the horrible rumors surrounding the city and its people, Etherians were not known for their charitable kindness. When he'd first arrived it appeared to be true, and very few in the city wanted much to do with him at all. But after being seen for a few months they'd accepted him with open arms. The elderly couple who used to cross the street to avoid him giving their warm hellos in the morning. The grocer who'd nearly refused to sell him food that first day now knew his order by heart. The laundress giggled at his jokes, the carriage drivers spoke with him, and sometimes children would even swarm him to ask questions about his home.

And yet, it hadn't meant anything until that day when muck and mud seeped through his pants after drinking a cure all.

These people were *soft* . They were overly accepting once they deemed you nonthreatening. They were gullible and scared and naïve.

Ripe for the picking, really.

So Prime had begun to learn more about the ancient blood that the very founding stones of the city were steeped in. He went into cathedrals and churches alike, spoke with doctors and healers; apothecaries had proven to have some of the most practical knowledge of the lot. He studied. He experimented too. Buying several brands of cure all's, cutting his leg before drinking to record the results. Once narrowed down he'd approached the manufacturer, if they could even be called that. Each vein of ancient blood was a closely guarded secret, its rotted and clotted red gold too precious to be shared without risk of the source running dry. As such, each vein was known to only a few and the medicines they made were a closely guarded secret. He chose the one that had the highest concentration of blood and after months of pestering, was finally pointed towards the Mystacor College of Magic.

He wasted no time in packing and leaving, his arcane powers had always been strong and his need to know ever more was an insatiable black hole. His acceptance to the college was a foregone conclusion as soon as he'd desired entry. Mystacor knew the entrances to deeper sections of the catacombs, from which the blood came, and Mystacor accepted him into their fold like a long lost brother.

You see, the people of Etheria *were* a backwater lot and seemed content with their miserable existence. He could help them, save them even, but he needed a source of fresh blood to ensure his influence to continue providing them his benevolent aid.

Something much stronger than what the people used. Something they'd never waste in their little rituals with the dead.

A miracle.

They would beg him for true miracles, and Prime would grant it. He could do what no person or kingdom had by bringing Etheria to its knees before him.

"Provost?"

Prime smiled languidly back at his most promising students as his mind cleared, inner eyes closing once more. "My apologies, I'm afraid I was lost in thought."

"I was asking if you knew when we would be allowed back into the labyrinth." Light Spinner asked, lightly as if she was merely curious but, oh, he knew better.

She was one of his most promising students and had happily taken on any task when he had fired Norman and replaced that old goat with her. Light Spinner was smart, clever, and powerful. She was also hot headed, impatient, stubborn, and very easily manipulated. Prime was well aware that she had to be kept far away from his true plans, or else she would ingrain herself into them. A most annoying little termite, but one who's ingenuity he could respect.

“Soon, I have found a few prospectors who believe they’ve found new routes into deeper, unexplored sections. I will go with them first and once I’m assured any beasties are handled, we will begin our own expeditions.”

Light Spinner’s green eyes nearly glowed with excitement and rage, a spark well hidden from most as she nodded. She had been one of the college’s top prospectors herself, and was more qualified than any of the unfortunate bastards he had hired, and she **knew it** . Spinner’s hunger for knowledge and power were well known and unrivaled amongst her peers and it had effectively allowed him to neuter her by giving her the position she had craved so dearly.

It was not proper for someone of her rank to go gallivanting about after all. Let loose, she would find them new paths and easily cast her spells (or deftly use her sword) to move them further into the depths towards a wellspring. And if she found a fresh source, his plans would be ruined. So instead, he hired those who could get the job done and nothing more.

Of course, she couldn’t simply accept being bested even when it was by her betters, changing tracks to ask, “Is the drink not to your liking?”

Prime smiled warmly, “It is perfect, thank you. I’m afraid I simply overindulged at dinner and I’m not quite sure where I’ll fit it.”

Of course she’d point it out, remind everyone that he was a foreigner, and draw attention to his mostly full glass. As if he didn’t worship the blood daily, more ardently than any Etherian. The drink was fine, a daily dose to keep the body healthy according to the locals. He’d simply begun to crave something with more iron and less water.

His own vein was jealously guarded after all, and the pure blood had become essential to his studies.

Light Spinner smirked nonetheless, confident in her victory. Always desperate to win a battle and never the war.

Prime quietly bid his farewells, retreating to his office. Mystacor had been his personal playground for years now, his tenure as the head of its research solidified. There were few places more secure than his office. His fingers traced delicately around the tentative map he’d made, rechecking the route he planned to take. He was so close now to a source, he knew it. He could feel the thrum of magic grow stronger each time he went below the surface and there had to be a path forward.

He would find it. He would find it and with it, he would control the last of the world's powers.

It was a pleasant thought to fall asleep with.

Chapter End Notes

So it has finally begun. Forget my goal to post a chapter a day during the month of October for spooky season, this AU has been (much like the video game) ruthless in kicking my ass and punishing me for any mistake I make. So we're gonna update VERY sporadically and without any update expectations for my sanity, such as it is.

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

The Heart of Etheria can only remain a secret for so long.

Below the current surface level of Etheria is another whole city buried under the new foundations. Below that, yet another, and another, and another.

The catacombs, or the labyrinth, depending on who you speak to, are possibly the worst kept secret by the college. Everyone knows that's where the sources of blood come from, many even know it's where monsters are born. Deep underground where arcane magic is its strongest, the one or two hours of torch light combined with the very real possibility of being killed prevent most from wandering too deep. Most.

Hunters, of course, have never been most people. Ancient factions and orders formed during the pandemic that most attribute to the fall of the First Ones to hunt monsters and beasts. Today they are more ceremonial. Prime had been nervous the first time he'd met a hunter, a jolly giant of a woman carrying a great hammer that would have crushed him dead in seconds. She was a local official, elected to manage the small area of Etheria where he had moved. Despite her pleasant attitude, he'd known that she was judge, jury, and executioner. No one would question a hunter's choice and the hunters kept the peace.

Ironic, considering their occupation and origins.

Prime had seen many badges as he wandered Etheria, often it was the only way to know whose jurisdiction he had stumbled into. The laws and politics of Etheria were heavily divide among the population, all proud Etherians and all mistrustful of one another. But he'd never seen more hunters than when he started going into the catacombs.

On occasion he would cross paths with a sane one. Someone who had dipped down for "communion". Most had come down for the endless hunt or become enthralled to it.

When he'd first met Light Spinner she had been a hunter herself, wearing the badge of the prospectors and rarely surfacing from underground. The rumors about her at the college were salacious and outrageous, the ones from the prospectors painted her like a hero or god. Prime had become a bit obsessed with trying to connect with such a powerful potential ally, someone he knew would back him up in deposing of Norwin. Each time he delved below grounds he requested her personally, and each time was denied.

"She has not been back recently." Prospector Hope had calmly told him, her voice a steady and even thing even as she pulled her saif from the raw and mangled rib cage of a shambling corpse. There was no blood, but the sound of bone on metal was becoming rather familiar all the same.

Prime smiled tightly as they turned from the pile of newly deceased to climb down the ladder to the next level. "I thought you said she checked in a few weeks ago?"

“Yes.” Hope slid down the ladder and clarified when he gave her a pointed look, “We meet in the mid levels. It is a suitable arrangement.”

“You do not fear she’ll turn?”

It was a fair question. For every handful of walking corpses and mutated creatures they found, it seemed a blood drunk hunter wasn’t far behind. Prospectors were the most likely to turn, the most active in the hunt and the only faction to consistently subject themselves to the unknown of the labyrinth it was only logical. Light Hope herself seemed to manage it by ruthlessly crushing her own emotions, never taking joy nor sorrow from any encounter. Someone like Light Spinner though? Oh, impulsive, emotional, temperamental Light Spinner? The gods would love to eat her whole.

“No. She has purpose still.”

Horde Prime almost missed Light Hope at times. She lacked much in the way of company but had been competent and skilled, often when they’d surface at Mystacor his clothes would still be pristine even as she dripped blood onto the tiled floors. She accepted coin and coldblood in payment and always allowed him to keep anything that struck his fancy.

It was a shame he’d had to kill her, truly. But she stood between him and Spinner, between him and progress. Prime had made sure to cut her down into small enough pieces for the rats, each

section looking more and more like cuts of pork. Flesh and fat and blood. A pity really, but he did not regret it.

Even if he could not wait for the damned buffoon who traveled with him now to meet a similarly horrible fate. The bastard was *whistling* , carelessly holding his torch and causing the greasy black smoke to drift back into Prime's face. It made him long for Hope's steady presence once more.

But he was greedy for gold and foolish enough that none would be surprised should he go missing. Qualities that Prime required when delving below the city.

He drew strength from the stones themselves, so deeply entrenched in magic that they sang to him. *Just a little more, just a little further!* Prime held to their promise as he coughed, the stench of decay and smoke and incense overwhelming him.

"Alright back there?" The man called back, smirking over his shoulder.

"Yes, quite alright." He smiled back, wishing he could simply bash his thurible through the hunter's skull. "We are getting close now, after all."

Thank all the gods.

Yes, Prime had spent many years below ground since becoming provost. Untraditional, but he had been elected for that reason. The upper levels were known well enough that Prime himself could guide others amongst them. The mid levels were familiar still, and even these lower levels were starting to make sense. Last time they had managed to to make it into a deep series of winding tunnels and he'd felt the magic so strongly he knew he was close.

So close. The sweet, sluggish pulse of magic became a rhythmic ecstasy this far down. Shimmering so brightly that he could glimpse the wider universe in darkened corners where it pooled. Twinkling and twisting stars that looked so familiar and foreign before vanishing like smoke leaving an ache in his heart. The magic of this place, the wellspring, so close he could almost taste it. Acrid and fizzing amongst the dust and mildew.

He would find it today, he was sure of it, but he needed to keep control to do so. Not drown in the arcane tempting him, and not lose himself in a growing irrational bloodlust. No matter how tempting it was.

Prime closed his eyes and breathed deeply. Concentrating until his head felt fit to burst, searching. *Show me.* He could feel his many eyes open in the dark, peering through the waves of magic and searching. Each time he was compelled to look somewhere else he pushed back and looked closer. *I see all.* He giggled, softly under his breath as the walls parted before him, no match for his power and- there. The air thrummed with energy, quivering, and he paused. Searched. The screams were starting, and he was nearly out of time. He forced himself to be bigger, more imposing, more powerful than this veil. *Where!?* A ripple.

Prime blinked slowly, closing his eyes to physically see once more and turned to survey the empty corridor they had been walking through. Here? *A door, perhaps?* He squinted through the flickering torch light, pacing back and forth until he was sure he knew the location that wished to be hidden from his sight.

Thank the gods his hired man was finally silent, waiting for him to make a call. It was this direction, either a false door or seeping through the rocks from a hidden entrance in another room.

Prime frowned, forehead and hand pressed against the cold and crumbling stone wall to reach. He could feel the pulse of magic, but it was...strange. Powerful and weak at the same time, for all it urged him to turn away, his own will demanded he press onward. In all his explorations, he had found many locked and hidden doors, but so too had he always found another path. This was no different. Unyielding shadows before his light; they would break. Prime's hand curled instinctively as he snarled. Small amounts of grit stuck beneath his fingernails and he decided it was time to do something foolish.

"Prospector," his voice was deep and smooth, a hint of the magic he dipped into dripping from his breath, "your hammer please."

The man paused, clearly unhappy about the request but handed it over with a gruff snort to try and hide his displeasure. A coward too then, scared of that which he did not understand. "Have at."

Prime ignored his grumbling, focusing solely on the trick weapon in his hands observing the mechanism to transform it before he gave it a few experimental swings. Again the urge to turn on the prospect came, stronger than ever. He could picture it. The spray of blood as white shards of bone scattered about. The man's terrified howling, pain filled eyes as he begged for his life. Would he have eyes on the inside? It was so tempting to check, to take them for himself, to absorb what little this pitiful creature could give!

Something he had learned since coming to Mystacor was that the more you desired something violent, the less likely it was to be you.

Yes. He was very, very close indeed.

Without any fuss, he activated the furnace and swung with all his might at the wall. The noise was awful, dirt and debris shaking from the ceiling as the many roots growing through the ancient stones rattled together. Pain shot up both of his arms, a white hot throbbing that caused him to nearly drop the borrowed weapon. And for one horrendous moment, the wall looked unchanged and untouched, before it *faded* away completely.

"Ahhh, I see." Prime absentmindedly passed the hammer back to the now wide eyed prospector. "Very clever."

He pulled out his torch and stalked forward.

His eyes were drawn to the walls, strange. This far down the architecture was primarily that of the First Ones, but this was…the middle Etherian style, wasn't it? It was a newer style, and one defaced with First Ones markings. Of course they *would* put their awful little touches everywhere, but how? Perhaps it was the magic, he reasoned, there were a few known instances of time travel, this could be but one more. Why? The eternal question, wasn't it?

He traced along one and felt the hair on his body lift. It drew magic in; the carvings. Prime twisted to look past his escort and he could almost see the standing pools from outside coming in. How very curious.

He stared at the line until his vision blurred before looking down the hallway with a grimace. The walls had changed. Or he had changed. They looked…unreal. Rounded and soft, as if the stones grew into shape, harsh and filled with right angles like metal poured into a mold. Unnaturally the most natural thing he'd ever seen. *Well, well, well, now we are getting somewhere.*

The man behind him huffed with frustration, and Prime forced himself to not snap. It was an honor to attend to the descent of Mystacor's finest but like so many, this man cared only for what little trinkets or baubles could be found to sell. Could he not see the artistry of this place? Not feel the euphoria of discovery? Did he not see the shifting grains of time right before his very eyes?

No matter.

It was no matter. He could not spare a thought for the hunter.

Turning ahead once more he smiled as he realized they had indeed wandered to the end of the hallway without his notice. It turned sharply to the right, some unknown light source gently glowing from around the corner.

His senses came alive, and Prime lowered his torch. Mostly hidden behind the roots was a mummified body. Its mouth open in an eternal scream, clumps of hair swayed in a slight breeze that he could not feel. It was pinned to the wall by jagged black metal. Almost as if something had thrown a spear made of molten iron slag that cooled on impact. Dripping and leaving barbs in its wake. The magic inside of them hissed, and he smiled. Perfect.

“Why don’t you head forward?” Prime made sure his voice was silken, framing his order as a request. It wouldn’t do to alert the man to the horrible fate awaiting him. “I wish to make notes here.”

“You’re the boss,” The prospector smirked under his hood and quickly walked without fanfare, eyes already darting around for anything that shined too brightly. At first there was just the sound of his boots and crackle of his torch, then a call back, “Lots of bodies, there may be a trap of some-”

The pulsing, ever present magic changed into a wild thing, raging joyously.

Dhump. Dah-dhump. Tha-thump. Tha-thump tha-thump tha-thumpthathump -tha-thump THA-THUMPTHA-THUMP-THA-THUMP!

Tears pricked at the corners of his eyes, the rapture of such power nearly bringing him to tears.

The man howled, screeching and wailing as he ran back, and Prime glanced around the corner in time to watch him collapse with a gurgling gasp as the black metal sprouted from inside his own chest and neck. Already spears shot out of his arms and sides, rivulets of blood pouring out even as the metal pulsed and twisted. Traveling further under his skin, raising it until it hung loose around his muscles. Glorious. Beautiful.

The man wriggled and writhed as his bloodied hands reached weakly for one of the spikes. As if he could pull them out to save himself, before turning to silently scream for aid.

At the end of the room, the doorway filled once more with orange light.

“Yes. It would seem that way.” Prime smiled as one last spike grew from the prospector’s mouth. Cracking his lower jaw into pieces and scattering his teeth killing him instantly.

With a thoughtful hum, Prime put his torch into the nearest empty holder to free his hand. It would do him well to keep his profile

small. Another glance did not seem to trigger the light and after a moment's consideration he had a plan. It was easy to see the many bodies that littered the room, but none along its walls. He carefully made his way along the edges of the cut stone floor, pressing his back firmly into the walls as he creeped along. One body, a skeleton more than anything, was close enough for him to touch the spear.

The ancient magic fizzled away under his touch, leaving his heart racing. A frenzied sort of magic, emotional in nature. He made a mental note to send someone for samples, there had to be a way around it after all.

It took a scant few minutes to make it to the doorway where the orange light had poured out, and he paused to let out a heavy breath of relief. What he would give to have Hope here with him, but alas it was now up to him and whatever it was in the other room it could not leave its place. His mind raced before cautiously pulling out his compact mirror to check around the corner. He'd endured the teasing over his own vanity, but no one ever seemed to conceive of a use for the device beyond fixing his own makeup.

Without a direct line of sight Prime was not in danger of its magic, and through his mirror he finally, finally saw the source. At first his mind skittered, nervous by the power radiating from the creature or perhaps being redirected away, but little had ever had a chance against his curiosity.

It was...a mass of some kind. An amalgamation of small pulsating muscles and roving eyes, but at its core it was a beating heart. Yes, a giant beating heart pulsating irregularly. Large roots came to and from its glistening flesh and buried themselves deep into

the walls. He noted with interest their similarity to the roots throughout the labyrinth, but were those were old and gnarled. These shone in the dim light, darker in color and beating much like the heart itself. His quick inhalation was enough to make the eyes dart towards his mirror, all of them seemingly able to see Prime as it screamed and began to burn with orange light.

But it did not hurt, no. He *saw* the truth.

The desiccated bodies from thousands of years littered the room he was in, a small stone altar he'd been unable to see in the gloom it's only decoration. Prime blinked and before him were the ancient First Ones, worshiping and praying at the alter- then older still a memory of humans doing much the same but without the gaudy gold and precious jewels. Then animals which roamed an open space within the woods. Crystals violently raised and rocks quickly formed from thin air as the heart sank beneath the soil for its own protection, ripping free of the trees violently and leaving pools of blood and petrified flesh behind. Feelings flashed by so quickly and so monumentally that only their impression was left, and the sense that he should know what they meant.

Prime was barely still himself, but always there was enough of him to ask the infernal question. Why?

Why would a creature so powerful need protection, what could it be hiding from? He'd barely wondered when the words echoed within his mind. His own voice and the scrap of chalkboards and the breaking of glass. Words in an unknowable tongue, his native language like the sweetest fire dripping down his throat.

It sighed, not quite audible, but almost as if saying-

Mortals. Always ***digging*** *.*

Prime snapped the mirror shut and collapsed to the floor panting for air, hand frozen as he tried to both open it once more and also destroy it in his own grip. A crossroads of desires. Ah. Yes, this way lay madness but curiosity was so very human, wasn't it? Their greatest strength and weakness, this need to learn more. The arcane arts had always come with warnings for the practitioners of it, that diving too far, like carving too many eyes inside your skull, would ruin you. Twist you.

He'd seen it, good people transformed into sickly creatures. Some would begin to glow unnaturally before descending into the labyrinth one last time. Others writhed upon the floor, boneless and broken and weeping. Old and young, weak and strong, all could fall to the madness if they were not careful.

Prime had stood at the precipice many a time now, and unlike the rest he was not so foolish as to be unprepared. Plans within plans within plans. He had pushed the research of the college beyond what was thought possible and it was his care and forethought that allowed him to tread lightly along the edge without falling. Seeking and envisioning every path forward before ever taking that first step. Etherians thought themselves so mighty within their ancient arts, yet their pride and stupidity were their own undoing.

And so Prime would light the way for them instead. Yes, he would find the way.

Gods his head was *spinning* . He felt so damned nauseous, but also- but also perhaps one more look? No.

Light the way. Carve the path. The pit threatened to swallow him whole in his haze.

He would not fall now, would not allow it. Prime eyed the bodies, and looked once more at his mirror. If it saw him directly it was death. Too powerful, this heart. Even through the mirror he had not been able quiet his disjointed thoughts; still they grew fighting for his attention. He tried to center, find the very core of himself to no avail. Each thought was louder and overlapping and- his mind rippled and hissed and he finally saw it.

He finally saw it.

Ah. Prime nodded slowly as he understood now, ringing in his ears. He could finally hear its name between beats, between songs. Ah. He understood now. *The Heart of Etheria.* Yes. A *powerful being* , no creature at all. He nodded slowly. Ancient. Powerful. He understood now. Strong. *Ancient.* The Heart of Etheria. Yes. A being of *power and magic* . Magic. *Ancient magic* . Powerful. Strong. Yes. His mind rippled. *Yes.* An ancient powerful being. Magic. Yes. Strong. An ancient powerful being of *arcane* magic. *An ancient one,* an ancient one, an ancient oneanancientoneanacientone. **The Heart of Etheria.** Prime nodded slowly.

Ah. Yes, of course.

He closed his eyes and stayed on the damp stone floor to breathe. He let the cold and dew seep into his clothes, into his body as he calmed his heart and emptied his head. Slowly finding a way back. Away from the aching that felt so addictive. Like pulling a tooth, painful and satisfying. Prime waited for his mind to clear and when he opened his eyes, his heart raced once more.

An ancient one. Fresh blood pumping within its body. To drink from the source was to know more was to enter the dream in which his mind could comprehend it, and there was truly no time for *that* . But oh...the things he could learn! He hopefully looked around but saw no obvious spring and cursed his luck.

The secrets revealed from even a single drop could change the world as they knew it! Healing- true healing and the power that came with holding such knowledge, yes, but he knew there was more within it. Arcane powers perhaps, a deeper insight into the unknown? So much that could be learned and discovered. But how to reach it? How to reach The Heart to gain even a single sip without falling victim to its protections? How… a root above him twitched and shriveled and Prime smiled fondly up at it. Not a root. An artery then. The Heart of Etheria pumped magic out into their world and took back… he wasn't sure. They could find a vein eventually to see what fueled it, but first he needed this artery before it shriveled away completely.

It took effort to climb back onto his shaking legs, more still to aim his whip just right. On the fourth try he cut the small remaining

bit of flesh down, and once he'd sufficiently caught his breath Prime stared lovingly at it. It was the power of the universe, literally, in the palm of his hand. His fingers curled tightly around the slick and oozing flesh, the screams through the door no longer a shriek, but instead distant to his own forming consciousness.

He would devote **everything** to this.

Every person. Every waking hour. If he could contain this ancient one, he would be able to perform miracles. He would become god-like!

Prime chuckled as he watched the severed tissue pulse in his hand, cradling it close to his chest as he left the catacomb to explore his finding. The college would grow with this and so would he. Etheria would bend the knee to beg for his love. The Heart pulsed warmly against his own, through hand and chest to nestle like a babe snuggling close to their parent.

Yes. An Ancient One.

And it was all his to use.

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